
Physik III

Autumn Semester 2026

Lecture Notes

Contents

1 Optics 1

1.1 Fermats Principle 1

1.2 Lenses 2

References

[1] Home, Jonathan: Vorlesungsskript Physik III. ETH Zürich. 2026

Physik III

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1 Optics

Optics is the study of light. It is relevant as light is everywhere. Furthermore it is a key tool for measurements in science. Furthermore, it introduces ideas associated with quantum mechanics. Historically, there was a wave and a corpuscle¹ picture of light. This wave/particle duality is the essence of quantum mechanics.

1.1 Fermats Principle

Fermat's principle tries to describe the path of light.

Proposition 1.1: Fermat's Principle

There are two different statements of Fermat's principle.

"Light travels by the route which takes the shortest time."

"Light will take the path which is extremal with respect to variations in the optical path"

The first statement is more intuitive, but the second statement is more general. For example, consider a setup with a mirror

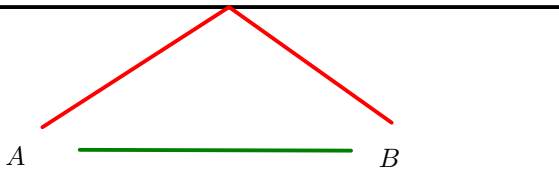


Figure 1: Two people seeing each other with a mirror

Definition 1.2: Optical Path

The **OPTICAL PATH** is a measure of time taken, written as distance.

$$D = ct = \frac{cs}{v}.$$

Where c is the speed of light and t is the time taken.

Recall that the speed of an electromagnetic wave in a medium is given by $v = \frac{c}{n}$, where n is the refractive index of the medium. Thus we can write the optical path as

$$D = \frac{cs}{v} = ns.$$

¹Light comes as particles

If the light has a certain frequency f , it will oscillate every $t_c = \frac{1}{f}$. So the number of cycles in a time t is given by

$$N = \frac{t}{t_c} = \frac{fD}{c} = \frac{D}{\lambda_0},$$

where λ_0 is the **FREE-SPACE WAVELENGTH** of light.

The optical path tells us how many cycles of oscillation we have covered on our path.

We now want to discover the refraction law using Fermat's principle.

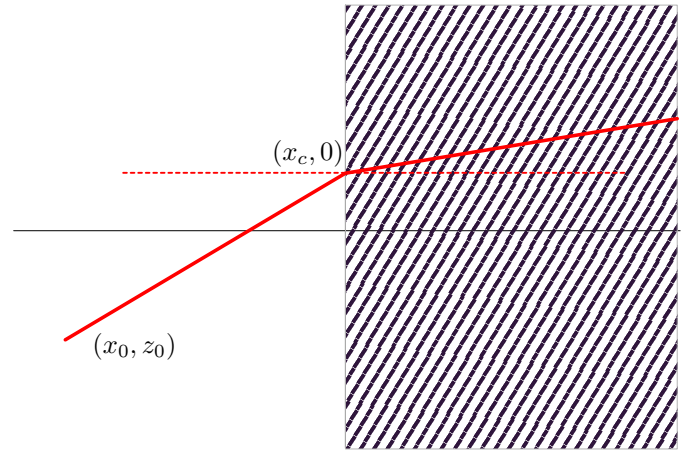


Figure 2: Derivation of Snell's law using Fermat's principle

The optical path in the left half is given by

$$D_1 = n_1 \sqrt{(x_c - x_0)^2 + z_0^2}.$$

In the right half, we have

$$D_2 = n_2 \sqrt{(x_p - x_c)^2 + z_p^2}.$$

So we want to minimize the total optical path $D = D_1 + D_2$ with respect to x_c . We have

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{dD}{dx_c} &= \frac{dD_1}{dx_c} + \frac{dD_2}{dx_c} = 0 \\ \frac{n_1}{\sqrt{(x_c - x_0)^2 + z_0^2}}(x_c - x_0) &= \frac{n_2}{\sqrt{(x_p - x_c)^2 + z_p^2}}(x_p - x_c) \\ n_1 \sin(\theta_1) &= n_2 \sin(\theta_2). \end{aligned}$$

Where θ_1 and θ_2 are the angles of incidence and refraction, respectively. This is known as Snell's law.

Theorem 1.3: Snell's Law

A light ray incident on a boundary between two media with refractive indices n_1 and n_2 will be refracted according to the law

$$n_1 \sin(\theta_1) = n_2 \sin(\theta_2).$$

1.2 Lenses

The best way to think of a lens is to think about the eye. It consists in principle of a lens and a screen (the retina). In principle, the lens is of refractive index n_2 in some sort of substance of refractive index n_1 . We are restricted by the shape and the refractive indices of the lens. Furthermore, we are restricted by the size of the lens.

Let us focus on the ideal lens.

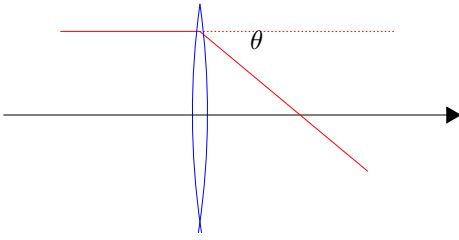


Figure 3: Ray bending of an ideal lens.

Light hitting the lens at a height h is deflected by the angle $\theta = \frac{h}{f}$, where f is the **FOCAL LENGTH** of the lens. Light incoming parallel to the optical axis will cross the optical axis at a distance f after the lens. The intersection is called **FOCAL POINT**. Here we make use of the **PARAXIAL APPROXIMATION**, which states that we only consider rays close to the optical axis, so we can use

$$\sin(\theta) \approx \tan(\theta) \approx \theta.$$

We will see, that in the paraxial approximation, if we have a non parallel ray incoming, it will still focus a distance f after the lens. In general, parallel rays converge after the lens in the **FOCAL PLANE**.

We now want to trace rays through a single lens.

By similar triangles, we have

$$\frac{\Delta}{\delta} = \frac{d}{s} =: M.$$

where M is the **MAGNIFICATION** of the lens. By similar triangles again, we have

$$\frac{\delta}{f} = \frac{\Delta}{d-f} \Rightarrow \frac{d-f}{f} = \frac{\Delta}{\delta} = \frac{d}{s}.$$

Hence,

$$\frac{d}{f} - 1 = \frac{d}{s} \Rightarrow \frac{1}{f} = \frac{1}{s} + \frac{1}{d}.$$

This is called the **LENS EQUATION**.

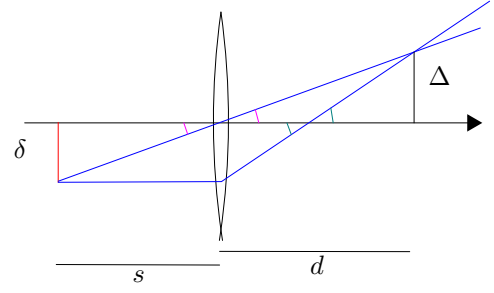


Figure 4: Derivation of the lens equation using ray tracing.

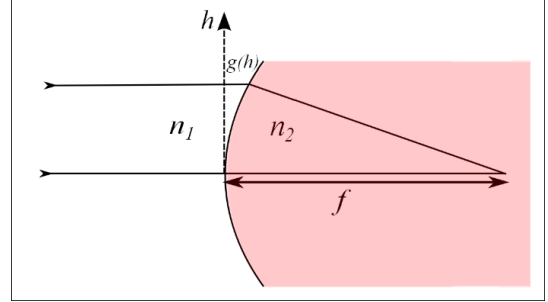


Figure 5: Setup of the surface lens.

Let us figure out how to design a simple "surface" lens. For this, we describe the profile by $g(h)$.

The optical path is given by

$$D = n_1 g(h) + n_2 \sqrt{h^2 + (f - g(h))^2}.$$

In general this is not really solvable, so we consider the paraxial approximation. So we have $h \ll f$. Since the lens should be symmetric we can assume

$$g(h) = \sum_n a_{2n} h^{2n}.$$

The simplest solution would be $g(h) = a_2 h^2$. Putting this into the expression, we get

$$\begin{aligned} D &= n_1 a_2 h^2 + n_2 \sqrt{h^2 + (f - a_2 h^2)^2} + O(h^4) \\ &= n_1 a_2 h^2 + n_2 \sqrt{h^2 + f^2 + a_2^2 h^4 - 2f a_2 h^2} + O(h^4). \end{aligned}$$

Using that $f \gg a_2 h^2, h$ we get

$$D = n_1 a_2 h^2 + n_2 f \sqrt{\frac{h^2}{f^2} + 1 + \frac{a_2^2 h^4}{f^2} - \frac{2a_2 h^2}{f}} + O(h^4).$$

neglect

Using the Taylor expansion $\sqrt{1+x} = 1 + \frac{x}{2} + O(x^2)$, we get

$$D = n_1 a_2 h^2 + n_2 f \left(1 + \frac{h^2}{2f^2} - \frac{a_2 h^2}{f} \right) + O(h^4).$$

Reordering the terms, we get

$$D = n_2 f + \left(n_1 a_2 + \frac{n_2}{2f} - n_2 a_2 \right) h^2 + O(h^4).$$

We want all paths to have the same optical path. So we want the coefficient of h^2 to vanish. This gives us

$$n_1 a_2 + \frac{n_2}{2f} - n_2 a_2 = 0 \Rightarrow a_2 = \frac{n_2}{2f(n_2 - n_1)}.$$

Unfortunately it is very annoying to make a lens with a parabolic profile. A spherical profile would be much easier.

Lenses in general are imperfect. Possible sources are:

1. Ignored higher order terms: symmetric about axis $\Rightarrow$ spherical aberration
2. Off axis aberrations: coma.
3. Chromatic aberrations: The refractive index depends on the wavelength of light. So different colors focus at different points.

Index

focal length, 2
focal plane, 2
focal point, 2
free-space wavelength, 1
lens equation, 2

magnification, 2

optical path, 1

paraxial approximation, 2